fortepianissimo

A card game of swapping, bluffing and betting on the best or worst hand. Loosely based on Blitz (31).

2+ players | **50** cards | **4** lives each

I What's in the game

50 cards, valued 1 to 10 in five suits:

 **Treble**  **Bass** **Sharp** **Flat**  **Eighth**

Each player has **4 lives** and two tokens: *M* **Major** ("I have the best hand") and *m* **Minor** ("I have the worst hand").

II Setup

1. Shuffle and deal **4 cards** to each player.
2. Deal **4 cards face up** in the center. This is the pool.

III Your turn

Play goes left of the dealer. On your turn, do one of these:

- **Swap.** Trade one card from your hand for one card in the pool.
- **Pass.** Keep your hand as it is.
- **Call *"Forte!"*** Only once every player has had at least one turn. Instead of swapping, place one of your tokens face down. Your hand is now locked.

IV After the call

Every other player takes **one last turn** (swap or pass), then places one token face down.

V The reveal

- Everyone shows their hand and flips their token.
- *M* Major is correct if your hand is the **best** at the table.
- *m* Minor is correct if your hand is the **worst** at the table.
- Wrong claim: **lose a life**. An exact tie counts as correct for everyone in it.

VI Winning

- At 0 lives you're out. The deal passes left each round.
- The **last player standing wins**.
- If everyone still in goes out on the same reveal, the game is a **draw**.

QUICK TURN

Swap one card with the pool, pass, or (after everyone's had a turn) call ***"Forte!"*** and place a token. Then everyone else takes one more turn and places a token. Reveal.

VII Hands, best to worst

Your four cards make a poker hand. A 1 is always low, and straights don't wrap (no 9-10-1-2). Hands are ranked by how rare they are in this deck.

	HAND	EXAMPLE	WAYS
1	**Straight flush** Four in a row, one suit	7♭ 8♭ 9♭ 10♭	35
2	**Four of a kind** Four of one value	6𝄞 6𝄢 6♯ 6♪	50
3	**Flush** Four of one suit	2♯ 5♯ 8♯ 10♯	1,015
4	**Straight** Four in a row	3♯ 4♭ 5𝄞 6♪	4,340
5	**Three of a kind** Three of one value	9𝄞 9𝄢 9♭ 2♪	4,500
6	**Two pair** Two pairs	8𝄢 8♯ 3𝄞 3♪	4,500
7	**Pair** Two of one value	5♭ 5♪ 10𝄞 2𝄢	90,000
8	**High card** None of the above	10𝄢 7𝄞 4♪ 1♭	125,860

"Ways" counts the hands, out of 230,300 possible, that make each rank. With five suits a straight is rarer than three of a kind, so it ranks higher than in regular poker.

SAME KIND OF HAND? HIGHER VALUES WIN

1. **Straights** go by their top card.
2. **Everything else:** compare the biggest group first (the three in three of a kind, the higher pair in two pair), then the other cards from high to low.
3. **Suits never matter.** A flush in one suit is no better than a flush in another.
4. **Exact tie?** Every tied claim counts as correct, so no one loses a life over a tie.

Both have a pair of 9s, so the next card decides:

Ana

9𝄞 9♯ 7𝄢 2♭

Pair of 9s, then 7: **wins**

Ben

9♭ 9♪ 6𝄞 3♯

Pair of 9s, then 6: loses